in the first innings, which I doubled to four in the second innings. In my defence, though, it was the first time I had ever opened the batting for South Africa.

I guess Hansie knew that the game was probably in the bag and that, having already been dismissed, the top five in the batting order would only be taking their small tog bags to the game the next day. And so he decided we were going to make a night of it. Six of us – me, Hansie, Daryll Cullinan, Jacques Kallis, Gary Kirsten and Pat Symcox, who, even though he still had to bat, was always game for a piss-up – appropriated the team Kombi and headed out to PE's infamous eatery and bar, The Ranch, where, it was rumoured, there were some very tasty off-menu dishes one could order should one feel the need. Symmo liked to claim that he was just 'in the wrong place at the wrong time' that night, but, knowing Symmo like we knew Symmo, no one ever bought his story.

The Ranch has closed down now, and I know I speak for all cricketers – the South African guys as well as any visiting international team who ever played in PE – when I say that it was a very sad day. The quality of the food was only matched by the quality of the waitresses and, as mentioned, rumours abounded that they were on the 'specials list' too.

The girls were indeed unbelievably pretty, and they all wore tight black dresses. There was supposed to be a room above the restaurant where one could allegedly get a little bit extra if you forked out the right sort of cash, but sadly I never got to substantiate that particular rumour. I do know, however, that one or two of my teammates – the single guys, of course – flew the odd Ranch waitress out to join them on tour.

Of course this evening with Hansie and the boys was by no means the first time I had visited this fine establishment. As a teenager, with the Western Province team, I had accepted many an invitation to join the likes of teammates Kenny Jackson, Adrian Kuiper and Meyrick Pringle for an evening of entertainment at The Ranch. As I recall, Meyrick was particularly fond of the place … and fond of a few beers too.

Back to Hansie, though – he really surprised me that night. And I'm sure a few South African cricket fans are also surprised to hear that their national team was out on the piss midway through a Test, especially with the captain leading the charge!

With Hansie, though, you could never know when he was serious or when he was joking. He'd play a prank on someone out of the blue and